Casualties

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Rape/Non-Con

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Kittrina/Akrash

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by Paganaidd

Summary

The world was ending again.

For the second time in her life Auravelle had used her knives to deal out death. The bodyguards had fallen easily. The arrogant fools had not given a thought to watching their own backs.

Her blade bore the Nine Winds' crest and she left it as a message.

Princess Kittrina was under the protection of Nine Winds now.

While Akrash and Catra race in pursuit of the Princess, Auravelle holds the line in Halfmoon.

Side story about the events in Halfmoon in the aftermath of chapter 127

The world was ending again.

Askar caught the Queen as she fell and took off with her at a dead run.

For the second time in her life Auravelle had used her knives to deal out death. Trishiam's body guards slumped in heaps off to the side in pools of their own blood. The first time she had killed she had felt nothing but horror, but right this second, a savage, *righteous* glee filled her.

In her arms Kittrina trembled with shock on the stone floor, two knives stuck in her side. With a wave of her hand, Auravelle cast the spell to keep the knives stable in the wound. Platelets in Kittrina's blood struck the metal and burst into mothsilk strong filaments.

Hold here. Hold strong.

Fibrous tissue wound around the blades, encapsulating the metal, blunting the edges, protecting the remaining tissue, binding it to the superficial layers. Swelling made the area rigid, closing off blood flow to an ooze.

Fierce pride filled her as she looked once again at Trishiam's body. Kittrina had done that; dueled Trishiam with *two* daggers in her.

The bodyguards had fallen easily. The arrogant fools had not given a thought to watching their own backs. Auravelle had reached them and stood ready. When Trishiam ordered them to attack Kittrina, she struck them down.

Her blade bore the Nine Winds' crest and she left it as a message.

Princess Kittrina was under the protection of *Nine Winds* now.

She was under *Auravelle's* protection.

A muttered spell made Kittrina no heavier than Isha would have been. “Put your arms around my neck, Kitt,” Auravelle whispered. She thanked the hidden Stars Above that she could be there for her old friend and help his love.

Kittrina did not make a sound as Auravelle raced through the castle, dodging the stupid people who clogged the corridors.

They skidded into the Royal entrance, the Guard at the door yelping and opening the door for them.

No Lenio in sight. He must be looking after the Queen. Then she saw a healer she recognized from her apprenticeship. He wore the insignia of a fully qualified surgeon. “Geoff!” she shouted. “Princess Kittrina needs treatment. Two knives in her abdomen.”

“Aurella?” His eyes widened as he took in who she was holding. “Come this way.”

Someone must have seen them standing there. A gurney appeared underneath Kitt and Auravelle gratefully laid her weight down.

“What O.R. is empty?” Geoff demanded.

The woman took the head of the gurney, leading her through the chaos. “O.R. 3.”

Geoff flipped up Kittrina’s tunic to look at the wounds. “This your work?” he asked Auravelle. They had been in the same classes before she dropped out.

“Yes.”

“Looks good. You can assist me.” He typed into his tablet as they walked, putting the orders in. “What happened?”

“They stole Princess Isha. Princess Kittrina was stabbed defending her.”

“They stole…?” Geoff sucked his breath in sharply, but he did not break stride. Just shook his head, taking a second to refocus.

He was a couple years older than Auravelle. Old enough to have been on duty the night C’yarra had been taken.

“Okay, then,” he grunted. “Do you know Akrash’s ‘cold-sleep’ spell?” Geoff wasn’t a sorcerer, his talent was cutting and suturing.

“What?” Akrash had mentioned something about that to her some time ago.

“Cold-sleep. It will buy her time.” Geoff shook his head and held his tablet. “If you don't, I have it right here.”

Auravelle snatched the tablet. A journeyman level spell to stimulate a natural bodily state. Well within her scope.

Skipping the long explanation she went to the bottom lines.

Intention:Artificial hypothermia. Hibernation. Slow metabolism. Buy time.

Incantation: Sleep. Slow. Be still. Be cold. Be safe.

Sigil runes: Sleep. Cold. Safe

Her mind went to that scout Lenio had saved all those years ago. His lecture on hypothermia and mammalian diving reflex.

She squared her shoulders.“I can do that,” she assured Geoff.

“Your Highness?” The surgeon leaned over his patient as they hurried. “Princess Kittrina? We’re going to get those knives out of you. All right?”

Glassy eyes rolled open and Kittrina nodded vaguely.

“I’m casting the spells for the surgery,” Auravelle told her. “I’ll be right here the whole time. You won't be alone.”

Kittrina squeezed Auravelle’s hand. “Thank you,” she whispered.

Auravelle tapped a leyline as Geoff shoved open the doors of the OR. Casting the first command on Kitt’s wounded form.

Sleep.

Kittrina’s eyes slid shut and her hand went limp between one breath and the next.

A whole surgical team appeared as if teleported. Four masked assistants came over and transferred Kittrina from the gurney to the table. One wielded scissors to expose the wounds.

“Be right back.” Auravelle banished the blood from her hands, ducked into the changing room, donned a set of clean scrubs from their shelf, and cast a sterile barrier spell on herself. The old spells came as easily as the steps of the waltz.

She grabbed a cap for her hair, winding the whole mass up with a couple of hair ties and shoving it underneath. Her hairstick knives went into the pocket of her scrubs where she could get at them.

Returning to the OR, She took Kittrina’s hand again. The leyline trickled magic steadily into Kittrina through Auravelle’s focus: The thin, plain bands of indorium on the fingers of her left hand

Sleep. Slow. Be cold, Be still. Be safe.

Kittrina’s body responded easily, as though it had done this before. Shunting blood to her core, slowing her heartbeat, reducing her body’s demands. It always made it easier when a patient’s body recognized and agreed with a spell.

Shock had already dropped her temperature a little. Her heart slowed and she was under. Auravelle focused on the sigil, drawing it in the air with her free hand. Directing it to hang in the air above the monitor, gleaming silver so that the team could see it was working.

“Are we going to let HER practice healing here?” Someone, Auravelle didn’t see who, demanded.

“Get the fuck out if you have a problem with it. I’ll take full responsibility.” Geoff replied curtly. “She’s the sorceress for this surgery.”

The woman huffed and left.

“Good to have you back,” Geoff grunted at Auravelle. “Keep her cold and asleep, and I’ll do my thing.”

Geoff’s confidence heartened her. She stood at Kittrina's side, monitoring her vitals and the surgical spell work.

“She’s lucky.” Geoff grunted, his eyes relieved above his mask. “No major organs hit.”

Little by little, Auravelle shaped the stabilizing spells as Geoff worked. Keeping the arteries blocked as the surgeon removed the blades and then withdrawing the magic when sturdy stitches replaced brittle magic induced clots. Kittrina’s condition was too delicate to do much in the way of speed healing; she didn't have the reserves. Auravelle fed her vital life force as the leyline magic sustained them both.

"She's stable," Geoff finally said, straightening. "We're closing now. You can bring her out." He said to both the anesthetist and Auravelle.

Auravelle withdrew her magic from Kittrina’s body with a parting instruction to wake up. She dismissed the sigil. Someone else started running heated fluid through her IV.

Geoff glanced at her. "You should sit down. You look like you're about to fall over."

"I'm fine."

The surgeon rolled his eyes. “I’m going to assume you’re staying with the Princess? We’ll put you in the room next to the Queen’s. Are you injured?”

“I… “ Was she? She looked down at herself. “I don’t think so.” She’d killed two men today. She wanted to be sick. “I'm fine," she repeated.

"You're not." He gestured to a stool in the corner. "Sit. I'll finish up."

Auravelle hesitated, then sank onto the stool. The adrenaline was wearing off, leaving her feeling like someone had turned up the gravity.

She put her head down on an instrument tray and watched Geoff close the incisions with careful, precise stitches. Watched the nurses clean and dress the wounds. Watched them transfer Kittrina to a gurney.

Dragging tail, she followed them as they hustled her out of the O.R. into a recovery bed. The cold-sleep had been dispelled, but they would need to monitor her for a few hours before Kittrina was fully awake from the anesthetics.

Auravelle sat beside the bed with her head on it, listening to the bustling footsteps and worried voices just beyond the curtain. The buzz of barely controlled chaos. Finally letting herself feel the weight of everything that had happened.

She'd killed two people tonight. She'd saved a life. She'd been called a healer again.

Running footsteps and shouting right outside roused her.

“Geoff! There you are! Someone told me Lyra collapsed! I need an update! And I need someone other than me who can handle spell damage! Where’s Akrash?”

Lenio’s voice. imposing order in his infirmary.

“Boss!” Geoff’s voice cut through. “He’s with Princess Catra. Chasing down kidnappers! Spell damage - holy shit!”

Kittrina did not even flick an ear. Auravelle crept towards the door. She could help…

No. That was emergency surgery. Geoff just needed an assistant sorcerer and she was available. None of those spells were particularly demanding.

On auto-pilot she opened the door. Just to see.

In the center of the chaos, directing it, stood Lenio. He seemed unhurt, although his robes were bloodstained and he moved stiffly.

Floating behind him were Lerrys and Ariel, and staggering in after them was her brother Aden. He looked drained and worried, but otherwise fine.

Ariel. Lerrys. Two more people she kept close to her heart were hurt. She had just gotten Lerrys back in her life! Would Akrash ever forgive her if she didn’t at least offer to look at Ariel? The girl was precious to him - he’d told her so many stories of his sister and her escapades. He’d been over the moon with joy (and deeply frightened) when he’d come in for one of his checks and told her his sister had imprinted on the Princess’ seneschal.

She’d saved Imella’s life when it would have been smarter to abandon her. Imella had told Auravelle the whole story.

Geoff blinked, focusing on Auravelle standing in the half open door. “Aurella - Auravelle, sorry! Can you look at one of them? I need to take Lenio to her majesty.”

Lenio turned and his eyes lit when he saw her. “Good! Someone other than me who can handle spell damage! Excellent. Scrub up and take those two. I’ve got - Triana, I think? She’s close to her journey rank, I’ll send her to you. We have more wounded Guard coming in from fighting in two other sectors, and four injured scouts who ran into the assholes in the tunnels.”

He grabbed a nurse as she scurried by. “Call Arashu for me.”

She nodded and ran off.

Lenio shook his head. “He’s an ass, but he’s mostly competent these days. “ He pivoted. “Aden, help your sister if she needs more magic - do exactly as she says. The only one better than her at this was Akrash and he’s busy!”

As though sensing her surprise, Lenio’s sharp eyes met hers “I know you probably weren’t expecting to get thrown back into the deep end so fast, but I really do need you. There’s not enough of us. There’s never enough of us!” He grimaced as he stripped off his top robe and threw it at a linen hamper. “Half of those trained after I retired are barely qualified on things like spell damage. I have trauma residents. I have surgical residents. I have healers. I don’t have people who can handle the kind of crap this war has thrown at us.”

There was no hesitation in Lenio as he headed for the scrub room. “Someone give me an update on Lyra! Now!”

Auravelle felt like she was still on auto-pilot, closing Kittrina’s door behind her as she followed Lenio. An orderly laid out fresh scrubs on the sterile counter, kicking a laundry basket over to her as Geoff grabbed a tablet.

Before the orderly left, Auravelle grabbed his wrist. “Call over to Nine Winds. Tell Madame Bastet I’m here. We have three healers who can handle trauma injuries. And Jake used to be a combat medic. Ask her to send them. And then call Indira to arrange for security passes for them.”

“Lyari is with her majesty,” Geoff told Lenio. “Her examination and her instinct says cervical insufficiency. We can probably fix it, but she’s still weak from hyper-emesis. We’ve stopped the bleeding and have her on IVs. We started antibiotics, plasma, and pain meds. The babies seem fine based on our scans, but it’s going to have to be magical anesthesia. We can’t use Akrash’s spell on her at three months along, but - ”

Lenio was already awash in magic as he sterilized himself. He’d turned himself at an angle, keeping his torso away from Geoff’s view - but Auravelle saw. There was blood on his torso and a mostly healed wound.

“Go let Lyra know I’ll be there in a minute. Get me an OR for her and get the nurses prepping her. And I was serious. I want Arashu or another full healer in here to deal with the incoming casualties. The Temple healers have most of their people in hand, but I’m sure there will be spillover. And I’m sure there was fighting in other sectors of the city. Make sure we have someone at our desk on with first responders so we know where - “

“Already on it, boss.” Geoff responded. “I’ll handle that then scrub in for surgery.”

“Good!”

As Geoff slipped out, Lenio looked to Auravelle. “I’m fine, girl. Don’t look at me that way. Aster can’t even stab someone right. He missed everything important and I can heal my damn self.”

Auravelle pulled on her fresh scrubs and stared right at Lenio. “Let me look.”

He huffed. “Fine! Fine!” He held his arms over his head as Auravelle looked at the wound. It was clean. It was closed - and her diagnostic spells showed that he was right. It had missed anything vital and he had it numbed. He would pay for it later, but he was probably fine for surgery now.

“All right.” She handed him his scrub top. “I can handle it. Aden and - Triana, you said? We can do this. I already helped with Kittrina’s surgery.” She paused. It wasn’t the right time, but she had to say something now, because the right time might never come.

Her shame had kept her away from Lenio for too long. Her shame had kept her from asking for help. From asking him or Akrash to tell her if Aster had been right. If Lenio had agreed with Aster, it would have destroyed her.

“I…thank you. Lenio. Thank you - for - “

He turned and grabbed her in a sudden, tight hug.

“I wish you had come to me, Aury. I’m sorry. I should have come and asked you about why you left the program. But neither of us were thinking, just feeling. And I didn’t want to interfere in your life. And Aster… well, that bastard isn’t around anymore.”

He pulled back. “You know Her Majesty is going to ask me to take back over that damn school.” He laughed and shook his head. “I never should have retired. I was furious and hurt and I missed my boy. Thought I’d failed him. Thought he was dead at the hands of those two mongrels.”

“We’ll blame it all on them.” Auravelle wiped her eyes. “Do we know what poison is in Ariel?”

She changed the subject. Because it was time to change the subject and because they both needed the subject to change.

“It’s all in her chart. We have a counter-agent for it. Akrash brewed it up and he made plenty back when we first figured it out.”

Triana turned out to be a tall magicat with dappled orange and black fur. She was nervous, but seemed steady enough as Auravelle worked the diagnostic spells. They would tell her how to take apart whatever Aster had done.

But it wasn’t a spell. It was backlash. Bleed-off from something powerful caught them. Not full strength.

Aden hovered in the back of the room, vibrating with distress.

“Okay, what happened?”

“Ariel shielded us all when Aster’s spell backlashed. He locked the portal somehow. I was furthest away when it went off and my own protections, combined with her shield - I’m fine.”

Auravelle nodded, half-listening, half-focused on her exam. “Then it’s just a matter of time. Lerrys’ armor seems to have protected him. It’s basically just a magical shock for him. Ariel is more complicated.”

She took a deep centering breath. Portal energy backlash. Snakeman venom. How was Ariel even *alive*?

“Bring them back here.” Auravelle led them to the treatment room next to Kittrina’s. “Triana? I need the counteragent. I’ll get a line into her. Aden? How much magic can you donate? This poison is eating through hers.”

“I’ve got plenty.” He said stoutly.

“Okay. Put Lerrys over there. He’ll be okay just sleeping it off. When he wakes up he’ll feel pretty shitty, but he's not in danger.”

The steps of the dance came back to her, steadying her hands. Putting confidence into her step.

She put a line into Ariel’s hand herself, starting fluids and magical restoratives, following the treatment plan from the original injury. The wound had begun to reopen, but it wasn’t bleeding. Rather, the edges had parted like a torn seam and it leaked clear fluid.

At least her guts had not fallen out this time.

“Okay Aden, Give her a steady trickle. Not too much. This poison

just sucks the magic up. I don’t want to drain you dry before the antivenin starts to work.” Auravelle wondered if there was perhaps some splinter of metal still buried. She’d ask Lenio about it.

Aden put his hand on Ariel's shoulder, face grim with concentration, while Auravelle hooked her up to the room’s monitor.

Triana banged into the room with a bottle of bright blue potion. “Thanks.” Auravelle took it. “Get Aden a chair so he doesn’t pass out.”

“I’m going to hook this up and then we're going to hope it works like it says on the label.” She checked the instructions, drew up the potion into a syringe and then screwed it to the port in the I.V. The instructions said to push it slowly.

“Triana? Come do this. Slowly. Over thirty seconds.”

“Got it, boss.”

Tentatively she augmented Aden’s stream of magic with her own, watching Ariel closely as Triana slowly pressed the plunger.

A minute passed. And then two. Ariel’s pale skin made it easy to see the change the second blood flowed back into her face.

And then Ariel ripped her hand from Auravelle’s and clenched her fist, a sigil flashing then flickering out as she swung.

Triana was faster. “Nope!” She grabbed Ariel’s wrist and Auravelle ducked while Aden yelled, “Ariel! You’re in the infirmary.”

“Kesi?” Her eyes were wide and confused. “Where’s Kesi?”

Auravelle grabbed her shoulders and looked into her wild eyes. “She’s in Mystacor! You’re in Halfmoon! She’s safe, Ariel. I promise!”

Intelligence flooded into Ariel's face and she crumbled, curling around the pain of the wounds that still had not healed.

"Your magic is depleted. Do you remember what happened?" Auravelle whispered.

"Where's Akrash?"

"He's gone after Isha."

Ariel nodded, let her eyes slip closed. Relaxed against the bed.

"Triana? She needs close monitoring."

"Will do."

"Can you stay with them, Aden?" Auravelle's eyes were blurring. She needed a minute. "I've got to get back to Kitt."

"I'll come get you if anything changes." Triana said.

"Auravelle! As soon as you're done, we need you out here!" Geoff shouted. "We've got more spell damage and Lenio can't get away!"

A long breath and she tapped the leyline again, feeling vitality flood into her.

Oh, she was going to pay for this tomorrow.

She lost track after that. Time blurred into cases and orders. Every time she handed off a patient, another one appeared.

Someone, a nurse or an orderly came and took her order for a strong tisane. A few minutes later it appeared in her hand, She drank, savoring the brew. Hot as the Fires Below, dark as the deep caverns and sweet as a stolen kiss.

"Master Auravelle! I've got another!"

She nearly dropped her tisane when she heard the title attached to her name. But she turned to the nurse. “Put them in treatment room two. Let me gulp this and I’ll be there!”

Eventually, Auravelle walked out into the bustling hallway and no one yelled for her. Indira stood, leaning against the wall, reading her tablet. “Looking for Princess Kittrina? They just moved her. I told them I’d wait for you.”

Indira took her elbow. “Madame Bastet sent the healers and Jake. They got here five minutes ago. The healers all have cases and Jake is on triage. She also suggested that we call Mama Suki and Jilli’s to see if they could offer some people.”

Mama Suki and Jilli’s were the largest public houses after Nine Winds in the Moonlight Bazaar. During the epidemic their in-house people had staffed the Lower City’s clinics when the cave fever had hit the regular healers.

“They had a healer each and a sorcerer they sent over. Some of theirs were also certified as healer's aids. Arashu’s organizing them.”

“Wonderful. If anyone gives them a hard time, talk to Geoff. He already ran off one busybody. And Lenio will absolutely back anyone who knows what they’re doing, credentials be damned right now.”

“Lenio says you should go sit with Kitt, now that we’ve got a handle on this.”

Auravelle blinked. "A handle on it?"

"As much as anyone can." Indira's voice was dry. "The casualties have all been accounted for. Now we’re just… waiting. So get some rest while you can."

Auravelle let out a breath she hadn't realized she'd been holding. "Okay."

Indira led her to a door flanked by Guard. They saluted Auravelle.

Indira nodded curtly. “Thank you, gentleman.” She turned to Auravelle. “I’ve vetted every guard on this corridor personally.”

A nurse busied herself for a few minutes, hooking Kittrina up to the room's monitor. Finally satisfied, she left.

Auravelle closed her eyes, let go of the leyline she'd been metaphorically white-knuckling all night, put her head on Kittrina’s bed, still holding her hand, and let herself drift.

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Sharp infirmary smells filled Kittrina’s nose and her mind moved slowly through a hazy nightmare. The Council. Akrash. Aster.

“ISHA!” she screamed. Or she tried to.

Nothing but a weak croak came from her throat and she couldn’t move for the pain in her stomach.

“Kittrina! It’s all right! I’m here!” Auravelle was right by her side and took Kittrina’s hands in both of hers. She wore scrubs of all things, and her hair was piled on top of her head and covered by a cap.

“Are they… ? Did Akrash come back with her yet?”

“I… no.”

Kittrina tried again to struggle out of bed.

“No, Kitt. You’re hurt. They just did surgery on you.”

“Isha? Akrash?” she gasped again as if the answer would have changed in the last two seconds.

“They haven’t come back yet.” Auravelle softly confirmed.

Kittrina began to cry weakly and Auravelle squeezed her hands. “They’re alive though,” the hetaira whispered. “I can tell that much. Everyone who went out to track her. They’re still alive. And Isha’s still alive. And Akrash is tracking her down.” Auraville’s eyes glowed with conviction. “He will bring her home.”

Yes. That was right. Akrash would follow Isha to the end of either Eternos or Etheria. Kittrina knew she just needed to wait. She stared at the ceiling while her thoughts circled. Everything seemed fuzzy and confusing.

She remembered… Dueling Trishiam?

“Trishiam’s dead?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

She closed her eyes. Auravelle rested her cheek on Kittrina’s hand, purring softly to comfort them both. It kickstarted Kittrina’s own purr.

Some time later, she struggled toward wakefulness, out of uneasy drug dreams.

Auravelle was still there, reading on her tablet. She looked up when she felt Kittrina’s eyes on her. “Hey? You okay?”

“Hurts.”

Auravelle stood and picked something up from the counter. “I've got you.”

She fiddled with the tube in Kittrina’s arm. “You'll feel this burn.”

It did burn, but then everything got light and floaty. The pain receded.

“Better?” Auravelle sat again, resting her head on the mattress and stroking Kittrina’s face. “I can give it a boost with a numbing spell if it's not enough.”

“It's okay. What's happening?”

Auravelle winced, her ears tilting back. Not a good sign.

“Aury?” Kittrina’s voice shook, her stomach knotted with dread even through the fuzz of the medication.

Her ears came forward and she smiled thinly. “It’s okay, nothing new has happened.” She shook her head. “There's no news at all, at the moment.”

She sat up and picked up her tablet. “Cloudfoot looped me into the internal Royal updates channel. I've set it to ping only if news about Akrash or Isha comes across. ”

“How long has it been?”

“A few hours. It's late. The nightshift was just here to tell me they were taking over. You should sleep”

“Will you… stay with me? Please?” And then Kittrina looked away. She had no right to ask Aury that. The woman was obviously exhausted. “Never mind.”

But Auravelle took her hand. “Of course, I’ll stay with you.”

Kittrina’s body relaxed and she pulled Auravelle’s hand to her face, drifting off to sleep.

Quiet voices pulled her toward waking.

“Hello, Momma.”

“Aurella. I was just checking on my people and I heard you were in here with Princess Kittrina.”

“It’s Auravelle, Momma. We've talked about this. You can even call me Aury if you cannot bring yourself to use my professional name.”

A little silence.

“I’m sorry, Aury.”

“Huh. That rhymes. But, apology accepted I suppose.”

“Aury…”

“Are you practicing or did you need something?” Auravelle did not sound angry, just tired.

“I heard that you killed Trishiam’s bodyguards. Well done.”

“So, I got Princess Kittrina here without her bleeding to death. Lenio assigned me Ariel’s case. I ran triage and treated spell damage, I fucking got recognized for the very research you spent years begging me to burn and the one thing that impresses you is that I murdered two people?” She was whisper-shouting by the end. She caught herself and added, much more quietly. “But, yeah. Sure. Yay me.”

Her mother was quiet for a long moment. When she spoke, her voice was softer. "I didn't mean it like that."

"Then how did you mean it?" Auravelle's voice was flat. "No. Don't answer that. Just forget it." She sighed. "What did you want?"

"Nothing." Sarela’s voice was barely audible. "I just wanted to see you. I was worried."

"I'm fine." The words came out automatically, like a well rehearsed script

"No, you're not." Sarela's voice was quiet. "But I don't know how to fix it."

“I don’t know either, Momma.” Auravelle let out a long breath. “But maybe you’ll feel better knowing your oldest daughter isn’t raving mad?”

This silence felt heavier, the tiny sounds of feet shifting on the stone floor seemed loud. Fingertips drummed against a surface.

Sarela sniffed and cleared her throat. “When… When all of this is over… will you come home and talk? Please?”

“I’ll think about it.”

The door opened and shut. Kittrina could smell salt.

“Aury..?” She opened one eye.

Immediately Auravelle wiped her eyes and turned to her. “Kitt? Oh, shit. I didn’t mean to wake you.”

“It’s okay. Are you all right?”

“Yeah. I’m sorry, I didn’t mean for you to hear that. You don’t need my family drama.”

“You’ve been holding my hand through the worst night of my life.” Kittrina squeezed her hand. “I don’t mind.”

Auravelle laughed, a wet little titter. “That’s the pain meds talking. I promise my mother and I are usually much more annoying. Ask my siblings.”

Kittrina squeezed her hand again, and let her eyes slide shut, listening to the sounds in the halls. The late hour and the pain meds made her thoughts fuzzy and strange, but sleep wouldn’t come.

Giving up on sleep for the moment, she turned her head to look at Auravelle in the chair beside her.

Even in scrubs with her hair shoved into a surgical cap, the woman was beautiful. It wasn't just her surface presentation that made her so lovely. It was her whole presence. Her kindness, her steadiness, so like Akrash. And, like Akrash, she had lovely hands. Every move was a joy to watch.

She'd said that Aster never found her enticing and Kittrina was glad. Aster broke delicate things.

Except, Aury wasn't delicate. She was like her hairstick blades, an unbreakable edge artfully concealed in plain sight.

And Aster *had* tried to break her.

"Can I ask you something?" Kittrina finally whispered. "It… it's so stupid to think of now."

Auravelle blinked up at her. "Kitt, you can ask me anything."

"Now that it's real. Now that Aster's gone, Akrash and I can be together … assuming…"

"Akrash will be back." Auravelle said firmly. "So…?"

"Were you ever…? Did you and he…?" Kittrina's cheeks heated as her brain caught up with her mouth. Her ears pinned. She couldn't finish. That was private. What must Auravelle think of her worrying about that while Isha was kidnapped?

"Oh. Well, yes." Auravelle smiled and her eyes looked far away. "He, Lerrys and I. We… experimented. You know how it is." Her smile turned sad. "Gideon and I cuddled a lot. He once told me that he slept best between Lerrys and I. So yes, depending on how one counts these things, he was my first."

To Kittrina's horror, huge tears dripped from her face.

"Oh! Kitt!" Auravelle's gaze focused on Kittrina, eyes widening and irises slit with distress. "I'm sorry! I promise it wasn't… "

Not wanting Auravelle to mistake her tears, Kittrina sniffed and hurried on. “No. Please. I-I-I’m so glad you were there for him.”

The thought of how lonely Gideon had been as a boy made her cry with grief. The fact that he had those sweet moments with Auravelle made her cry with gratitude.

“When we saw that awful place where they kept him? I realized you, Lenio and Lerrys are the only reason he came out of it halfway sane. The stories Ariel tells about how their mother had to remove the spells are horrifying.”

Auravelle sniffed, giving her a watery smile. “Thank you.”

“Aster and I… He was my first.”

“So, you waited until marriage?” Auravelle tilted her head.

“I… no. I mean I wanted to wait but you know how you just get swept away sometimes?”

“Yes. Of course.”

“Well, you know, we got to that point and he…” Her voice choked off. She smiled tightly. “Sorry, it’s embarrassing.”

Auravelle’s soft smile didn’t change and she covered Kitt’s hand. “First times are always awkward.”

Kitt felt her cheeks heat. She reminded herself that Auravelle had probably heard everything.

“We'd been doing a lot of… cuddling. Then he just… I'm not sure how it really happened. We'd been drinking.” She hesitated. “I should have… I guess he'd gotten to the point where he couldn't stop.”

“Did you want him to stop?” Auravelle asked quietly.

Like that day in her office, Kittrina felt truth spelled. “Yes!” A low moan burst from her lips. “He hurt me!” She let go of Auravelle’s hand and tried to put her arms around the woman’s waist, giving a little squeak of pain when the movement tugged her stitches.

Auravelle moved back and Kittrina began to cry because she *needed* someone to hold her right then. “Shh. Kitt. It’s okay, I’ve got you.”

Delicately, Auravelle crawled right into the bed with her, gently taking her in her arms, mindful of the tubes and monitors.

Kittrina burrowed into Auravelle's floof, burying her face in her neck, taking in her sweet scent for a long time before she had the strength to speak again.

“I asked him to stop.” Her voice was high and young in her own ears. She took a breath. She wanted to blame Aster for everything wrong in her life. But she had to be honest with herself. “But I know when a man gets like that…”

“That's some bullshit.” Auravelle interrupted flatly. The curse sounded harsh and strange from her lips. “That's the kind of logic a child uses.”

Kittrina cringed a little because that wasn't wrong, but Auravelle put her hand on Kittrina’s cheek, encouraging her to look up into her light blue eyes, so different from Akrash’s sapphire.

“But Aster was no child. He was a *fully qualified master sorcerer*. If he couldn't control his passion, how could he ever sustain a complicated spell casting?”

“I suppose…” Kittrina *had been* a child when she wed Aster. She’d even been annoyed that they had to wait until she was eighteen because the newly crowned queen had just changed the law.

Six months before the wedding, he'd taken her to a gala. The first one they held in Lyra’s reign. Over a year after the failed coup that had stolen Gideon from Halfmoon.

They hadn't danced, but Kittrina had reveled in the chance to socialize with people her own age, wear a pretty dress and feel something other than sad.

They'd gone back to his rooms and happily planned their new home. They'd drunk too much wine and cuddled. She'd kissed him and then…

"Come on Kitt. You can't leave me like this. It hurts, you know?" And, "*We'll be married next month."* At the time she thought his smile was teasing, but looking back on it, it was a smug leer. "*You won't be able to say no then."*

And then, *"Anyway, I think we have an imprint."*

An imprint would make everything okay. So she'd stopped fighting him. She let him. Until it hurt and she gasped pushing against him.

"Don't be silly. It doesn't hurt."

As if she'd been seized with the freeze of a prey animal, she lay there letting him have his way. It hurt, but somehow it didn't matter, because trying to escape would make it worse.

Was that the first time he compelled her? Tears came down her face.

Auravelle wriggled around so they were nose to nose on the pillow, just far enough away so they could see each other clearly.

"I-I should have known. Grandfather… Askar… He was worried about the age gap between us…"

A deep growl interrupted her. "The problem wasn't the age gap. Lots of perfectly fine relationships have age gaps. The problem was that Lord Aster is an abusive prick."

She named it so precisely and harshly that Kitt actually giggled, high pitched and hysterical. What the fuck was wrong with her?

"And now, thanks to you, everybody knows."

Kittrina scoffed. "No, that was you, Akrash and Catra."

"No, Kittrina. It was you. We could do nothing until you stepped forward. You befriended Catra. You befriended Akrash. You kept doing all those fantastic projects with the Council. You kept being you." She paused and brushed Kittrina's hair back. "What made you leave him?"

Kittrina concentrated. That had been such a *weird* night.

"He raised his hand to me. Then he tried to say he hadn't. But it was exactly the way Celian used to raise his hand. When he wanted us to get the fuck out, you know? I don't know why that was the final straw." She thought back. "It was like… He was telling me to calm down and be quiet. But I couldn't get it out of my mind that what he *wanted* me to do was leave."

Auravelle was nodding. "Yes. Compulsions are strangely literal. The one he laid on you was probably fairly general. Like, 'Treat Aster well and do what he says.' And then he gives you mixed messages. A gesture that had a meaning he didn't suspect and you literally ran with it."

"But you broke his hold on you by yourself."

"Only because he miscalculated." Auravelle scoffed and met Kittrina's eyes. "I did not escape because I'm special, but because he tried to break me in the exact wrong place."

She sighed and cuddled a little closer. "If he'd have approached me as a mentor, every piece of research I ever did would be tainted and I would never have seen it. You think Lerrys was bad? I would have *found* evidence to support his story about Akrash."

"But Aster thought he could make me think I was *wrong.* " She shook her head. "That's where he fucked up with me. My own family disbelieved my research even before that. Much more kindly of course. My mother has always been legitimately worried

about my mental state. She begged me to stop researching all this ancient dark magic. She thought I was diving into conspiracy theories out of grief. Building Gideon up as a tragic hero in my mind. I never showed her the notebooks because I was afraid she'd make me get rid of them."

Kittrina remembered: Imella wouldn't even try to explain her oldest sibling. That day in Kittrina's office, Imella had called her 'Aury' and spoken in tones of gentle exasperation. Until Auravelle had pulled a knife on Duncan, Imella had treated her like a teenager with an overactive imagination. An imposition, as though she had no business in the serious world of Crown politics. Even as it became apparent she was bringing evidence to help Akrash, Imella told her to "*just write a letter*."

"Dramatic? I *adore* drama. Attention seeking?" She brushed the curls escaping her cap back with a wide glowing grin. "Obviously! And paranoid?" A throaty chuckle. "My father likes to say paranoia just means one is paying attention."

"The compulsion to become a drunk and a whore certainly worked. But I became the *best* drunken whore Halfmoon had ever seen." Her smile showed her fangs. "It's the over achiever thing."

She stopped, her expression sobering. "If he'd have told me he believed my research, I would have sucked him off then and there." She went on more quietly. "And I would never have looked back. I would have been in so deep, I would have lost myself forever. I would probably now be lobbying for legal rape and forced breeding." She reached out and cupped Kittrina's cheek. "I am so in awe of you." Her eyes held nothing but sincerity.

Kittrina melted into the safety of the woman's touch. "Of me?"

"Yes!" Auravelle's voice was fierce and she touched her forehead to Kittrina's as she whispered. "You kept being yourself. You built a life. You made friends. You trained the Guard. You held your

daughter and loved her even when you were being sabotaged. Akrash is really lucky to have you."

Kittrina started to cry again. "I don't know how to be with him."

"Shh. Shh. Kitt. He loves you. So much." Once again she held Kittrina in her arms.

Finally Kittrina felt ready to emerge from their huddle. She backed up and Auravelle instantly let her go.

"I'm so scared I'll disappoint him." She took a deep breath and bit her lip.

Auravelle didn't answer for a moment, rather she searched Kittrina's face as she stroked it. "Disappoint him how? I'm not sure I understand."

"He's had several lovers." Kittrina swallowed. "He's had *you*."

Aster's trips to the Moonlight Bazaar had made Kittrina mad with jealousy. He often implied it was because the things Kittrina liked were dull.

"Akrash never pined for me, I promise." Auravelle's voice was sure.

"Aster told me…" Kittrina flinched at her own words because in the weeks since she left Aster she had begun to realize that the way to tell if Aster was lying was to check if he was speaking. But he'd been the arbiter of her life for so long.

"He told me I was terrible in bed." She blushed so hard her ears went hot. "That was why he went to the brothel."

"I'd be terrible in bed too if I had to fuck *Aster* for free." Auravelle made a noise of disgust in her throat.

Kittrina blinked, another one of those ragged giggles torn from her at the absurd statement. Auravelle moved her hand from

Kittrina’s cheek to her shoulder, gently smoothing the fur on her arm as the giggles teetered on the edge of tears.

"I don't even know what I actually like. I never got to find out. I just spent years trying to be what he wanted, and I was never good enough. I was never going to be good enough. Because what he wanted wasn't a wife. It was a-a *brood animal."*

Trishiam had called her that: *‘breeder.”*

“Once I had Isha… I had to beg him to even hug me. But then when *he* wanted it… he’d just… And it always…” She closed her eyes and cringed.

The hand on her shoulder never stopped moving. “It’s not supposed to be like that, Kitt.”

For a long moment, Kittrina didn’t move. When she spoke again, her voice seemed small in the quiet room "Isn’t it?”

The words hung in the air. Words Kittrina had never voiced. Whenever she’d tried, a terrible dread rose up in her. As it did now.

But here in this little room, safe in Auravelle’s arms, she could whisper what she’d never been able to articulate until now.

“I thought that was just... how it was. How it was supposed to be." She swallowed. "When we got married, he said that I just needed to relax. That I would learn to enjoy it."

She bit her lip.

“I never did. It just… it didn’t seem important. So, I st-stopped telling him that it hurt.” A hollow, broken laugh rose from her chest. “I guess I shouldn’t blame him for that, I…” She sniffed. “I wanted to talk to a healer about it, but I couldn’t bring myself to ask one.”

Auravelle sighed. “I am so sorry that happened. I suspect Aster’s compulsion actively discouraged you from seeking help.”

“Is… is there help for something like that?”

“There’s a lot of reasons for pain during sex. And there are many ways to help.”

”What if I can't ever do it? What if I can't ever... be with him like that? What if we love each other and it doesn't matter because I'll always flinch when he touches me?"

She cringed, waiting for Auravelle to laugh and tell her not to be silly.

Instead, Auravelle gathered both of Kittrina’s hands into hers. “If Aster hurt you like that, we’ll find out. And if there is permanent damage Akrash will help you. And I’ll help you. That sort of thing is exactly where my usual work lies. I counsel imprinted people about this very thing.”

“I didn’t know that.”

“That’s all right. We can talk about it later.” Auravelle petted her arm again. “Your eyes are closing, Kitt. Why don’t you sleep? I’ll be here when you wake up.”

Kittrina had been fighting the pull of sleep for the last part of the conversation. Auravelle scooted up on the bed and raised the head. Then, she gently arranged Kitt so her head was in Auravelle’s lap.

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A long night stretched before her. Auravelle leaned back in the bed, petted Kitt's ears and stared into the gloom, eyes following the reassuringly steady tracing on the monitor.

Akrash would return with Isha or he wouldn't return. There was no third choice.

A fierce protectiveness rose in Auravelle's heart. If Akrash did not return, she would take care of Kittrina until she was well and they would hunt Aster down together.

That bastard had brutalized the girl Kittrina had been. It was there in the flinch, the "he said I'd get used to it." Kittrina wasn't accustomed to her pleasure being considered.

Akrash would understand that. Even as a boy, Akrash had careful hands and he had enough experience to know how to let her lead.

She let her vision slide out of focus, watching Kittrina's shifting energy, looking for the strange web of threads that bound her to every other person in her life. She asked the magic to show her the people uppermost in Kittrina's mind.

A dark red thread, thick as her little finger and sturdy as twine, bound mother to child, vital and alive. A cord of bright blue-white braided with Kitt's own copper-gold bound her to Akrash.

Akrash and Isha were both alive and well.

The specter of Aster inflicting hidden permanent damage on Kittrina was a terrifyingly real possibility, given what he'd done to Auravelle. But she had been telling the truth. If Aster had planted a nasty surprise in the layered spells, she would be there to help.

Kitt made a distressed little noise in her sleep. "Hurts" she muttered.

It was too early for more pain meds. Auravelle tapped a leyline. drawing enough power to cast a numbing spell on her injuries and Kitt sighed, snuggling more closely and purring.

Auravelle purred too, the resonance comforting and something shifted deep in her chest. A contentment unfurled, warm and sweet.

In her mind's eye she watched those shifting braided energies that were Kitt and Akrash’s imprint.

A flash. A glimpse of lapis blue in the weave.

What?

She focused. There. A thin thread of dark blue in the blue-white and coppery gold.

It was probably nothing. Kitt was just vulnerable. Kitt was terrified for her child. She was in need of support. They were both so scared for Akrash. That was all. And Kitt was on a bunch of pain meds. That definitely lowered barriers. Two frightened women bonding over their shared fear.

The minute Akrash got back, that little thread would fade out. Pushed out of the imprint as Kitt focused on him.

But Auravelle already knew Aster liked to leave booby traps in his magic. As she’d recently found out. What if she hadn’t found them all?

That was for tomorrow. For when Akrash returned with Isha. For when she had the energy to face it.

Now she was too tired to even think.

She closed her eyes and slipped into sleep, still purring in time with Kitt.

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